Follow the slider

A zipper clicks together.

Name _____ Date _____



Little Wonderer found the place where the pouch changed. Below the slider, two rows of zipper teeth stood apart. Above it, they made one joined row. The boundary moved whenever the slider moved. “So the slider must be doing something inside,” Little said.



Up close, each zipper tooth was really a shaped element. A rounded bump on one element fitted into a pocket on the other side. The elements alternated left, right, left, right. Interlock means to fit together so connected shapes hold one another in place.



The cutaway revealed a channel shaped like the letter Y. Two wide paths curved around a center wedge, then met at one narrow path. As the slider traveled upward, its angled walls nudged both tooth rows inward. The slider was a moving guide, not a row of teeth itself.

element	one shaped piece in a row of zipper teeth
slider	the moving piece that guides zipper elements together or apart
channel	a narrow path that guides something through
interlock	to fit together so connected shapes hold one another
wedge	a piece with sloping sides that guides things apart
stop	a small piece that keeps the slider from leaving the zipper
tape	the woven fabric strip that carries a row of zipper elements
flexible	able to bend without breaking

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Little followed the slider slowly. Its channel lined up one element from the left, then one from the right. Bump met pocket. The next pair followed. Many tiny interlocks formed one flexible zipper chain behind the slider. The slider did not pull the teeth straight across; it curved them into place.



Then Little moved the slider back. The joined row entered the narrow end. Inside, the center wedge steered one side left and the other side right. The bumps slipped out of their pockets along the curved paths. The same Y-shaped channel worked in reverse to open the pouch.



Little closed the pouch once more. The last elements nested, and the slider met the top stop with a neat click. The stop kept it from sliding off the teeth. Two rows had become one strong, bendable seam. Little looked at a jacket zipper. “Is the same hidden Y inside that one too?”

1. What evidence shows that the slider guides the teeth instead of gluing them together?
2. How do the Y-shaped channel and center wedge do opposite jobs when the slider changes direction?
3. Why can the closed zipper bend even though its elements are interlocked?

Your turn

Write one explanation sentence about the slider's hidden path.

Example: The Y-shaped channel guides two tooth rows into one interlocked row.